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SONG 88

Make Me Know Your Ways

FOCUS

What we must do to benefit fully from the advice we receive.

Why Seek Advice?

“Wisdom belongs to those who seek advice.” —PROV. 13:10.

ALL of us want to make wise decisions. And all of us want our plans to succeed. God’s Word tells us how we can achieve both of those goals.—**Read Proverbs 13:10; 15:22.**

² Of course, the best Person we can go to for wisdom and advice is our Father, Jehovah. He promises to help us, saying: “I will give you advice with my eye upon you.” (Ps. 32:8) This statement shows that Jehovah does more than just give us advice—he takes a personal interest in us and helps us to apply his counsel.*

³ In this article, we will use God’s Word to help answer four questions: (1) What qualities must I have if I want to benefit from good advice? (2) Who can give me good advice? (3) How can I keep an open mind and heart? (4) Why should I avoid asking others to make decisions for me?

WHAT QUALITIES MUST I HAVE?

⁴ We must be ***humble*** and ***modest*** to benefit from good advice. We need to recognize that we may not have the experience or the knowledge to make a wise choice

* In the Scriptures, the terms “**advice**” and “**counsel**” can refer to the same thing. In this article and in the one that follows, these two words will be used interchangeably.

1. How can we make wise decisions and have our plans succeed? (Proverbs 13:10; 15:22)
2. What does Jehovah promise to do for us?
3. What will we consider in this article?
4. If we are to benefit from good advice, what qualities must we have?

all on our own. If we do not have humility and modesty, Jehovah will not be able to help us. Consequently, any advice we do receive when reading God's Word may run off us like water off a stone. (Mic. 6:8; 1 Pet. 5:5) However, if we are humble and modest, we will be quick to absorb the Bible-based advice we hear and to benefit from it.

⁵ Consider what we can learn from the example of King David. His achievements could have made him become proud. Long before he ascended to the throne, he was famous for his ability as a musician. He was even asked to perform for the king. (1 Sam. 16:18, 19) After anointing David as the next king,

5. What achievements could have made King David become proud?

Jehovah empowered him with His holy spirit. (1 Sam. 16:11-13) He was popular among his people for striking down their enemies, including the Philistine giant Goliath. (1 Sam. 17:37, 50; 18:7) A proud man who had achieved such great things could have thought that he had no need to listen to advice from others. But not David.

⁶ After being installed as king, David kept close company with men who gave him advice. (1 Chron. 27:32-34) This is not surprising, for David had a record of listening to good advice. He accepted it not only from men but also from a woman named Abigail. She was the wife of the disrespectful, ungrateful,

6. How do we know that David welcomed advice? (See also cover picture.)

We should be willing to listen to good advice, no matter who gives it to us

(See paragraph 7)



and egotistical man Nabal. David humbly applied her good advice and, as a result, avoided making a terrible mistake. —1 Sam. 25:2, 3, 21-25, 32-34.

⁷ From David, we can learn some lessons. For instance, we may be talented or have a measure of authority. Even so, we should never think that we know it all and do not need advice. And like David, we should be willing to listen to good advice, no matter who gives it. **(Read Ecclesiastes 4:13.)** If we do, we will likely avoid making big mistakes that can bring grief to us and to others.

WHO CAN GIVE ME GOOD ADVICE?

⁸ Consider one more lesson that we can learn from David's example. He listened to the advice he got from people who had both a good relationship with Jehovah **and** a good understanding of the particular challenge he was facing. For instance, when wanting to know if he could restore his relationship with King Saul, David listened to the advice of Jonathan, Saul's son. Why was Jonathan able to give him good advice? Because Jonathan not only had a good relationship with Jehovah but also had experience in dealing with Saul. (1 Sam. 20:9-13) How might we apply that lesson?

⁹ When we need advice, we do well to consult someone who has a good relationship with Jehovah **and** experi-

ence in the matter we need help with.* **(Read Proverbs 13:20.)** For instance, suppose that a young brother is interested in finding a suitable marriage mate. Who could give him good advice? An unmarried friend might be helpful if he bases his advice on Bible principles. But the young brother is likely to receive advice that is more specific and practical if he consults a spiritually mature couple who know him well and who have been happily married for some time.

¹⁰ We have discussed two qualities that we must have as well as who can give us good advice. Now let us consider why we must keep an open mind and heart and whether we should ask others to make decisions for us.

HOW CAN I KEEP AN OPEN MIND AND HEART?

¹¹ Sometimes, a person might appear to be seeking advice, but in reality, he just wants confirmation from others about a decision that he has already made. Such an individual does not really have an open mind and heart. He should take as a warning what happened to King Rehoboam.

¹² Rehoboam succeeded King Solomon as ruler of Israel. Rehoboam inherited a nation that had been prosperous, but the people felt that Solomon had demanded too much from them. The people came

* Christians may at times wisely consult those who do not worship Jehovah regarding financial, medical, or other matters.

7. What lessons can we learn from David's example? (Ecclesiastes 4:13) (See also pictures.)

8. Why was Jonathan qualified to give advice to David?

9. Who should be consulted when we need advice? Explain. (Proverbs 13:20)

10. What will we now consider?

11-12. (a) Sometimes, what might we do? (b) What did King Rehoboam do when he had to make an important decision?

to Rehoboam and pleaded with him to lighten their burden. Rehoboam asked them to give him time to think about the decision he would make. He started well, asking for counsel from the older men who had helped Solomon. (1 Ki. 12:2-7) However, he rejected the advice given by these older men. Why would he do that? Had Rehoboam already decided what he was going to do and was just looking for someone to agree with him? If so, he found that confirmation in the advice that he received from his younger friends. (1 Ki. 12:8-14) Rehoboam answered his subjects according to that advice. As a result, the nation split, and from then on, Rehoboam had constant trouble.—1 Ki. 12:16-19.

¹³ What can we learn from Rehoboam's example? When we ask for advice, we must have an open mind and heart. How can we know if we do? We could ask ourselves, 'Do I ask for advice and then immediately reject it because it is not what I want to hear?' Consider an example.

¹⁴ Imagine that a brother has received an attractive job offer. Before he accepts it, he asks an elder for advice. The brother mentions that the job would require him to be away from his family for extended periods of time. The elder reminds the brother of the Bible

13. How can we know if we have an open mind and heart?

14. When we receive advice, what must we remember? Illustrate. (See also picture.)

**Are we really seeking good advice,
or are we just looking for someone
to agree with us?**

(See paragraph 14)





We should seek advice only after we have done our own research
(See paragraph 17)

principle that his primary responsibility is to provide for his family's spiritual needs. (Eph. 6:4; 1 Tim. 5:8) Suppose that the brother immediately finds fault with the elder's words and asks other brothers about the matter until he is told what he wants to hear. Is the brother really seeking advice, or has he already made up his mind and is just looking for someone to agree with him? We must remember that our heart is treacherous. (Jer. 17:9) Sometimes, the advice we need the most is the advice we want to hear the least.

SHOULD I ASK OTHERS TO MAKE DECISIONS FOR ME?

¹⁵ Each of us has the responsibility to make his or her own decisions. (Gal. 6:4, 5) As we have discussed, a wise person will seek advice from God's Word and from mature Christians before choosing a course of action. However, we must be

15. What must we be careful not to do, and why?

careful not to ask others to make decisions for us. Some might do that directly by asking someone they respect, "What would you do if you were in my situation?" Others might do it more subtly by copying what somebody else does without thinking deeply about the matter themselves.

¹⁶ Note the situation that developed among the first-century congregation in Corinth regarding meat that may have been sacrificed to idols. To those Christians, Paul wrote: "We know that an idol is nothing in the world and that there is no God but one." (1 Cor. 8:4) With this fact in mind, some in the congregation decided that they could eat meat that may have been offered to an idol and later sold in a meat market. Others decided that they could not eat such meat with-

16. What situation developed in Corinth regarding meat sacrificed to idols, and who had the responsibility to decide whether to eat such meat? (1 Corinthians 8:7; 10:25, 26)

out disturbing their conscience. (**Read 1 Corinthians 8:7; 10:25, 26.**) This was a personal decision. Paul never advised the Corinthians to make decisions for others nor to copy what others did. Each of them was to “render an account *for himself* to God.”—Rom. 14:10-12.

¹⁷ How might a similar situation arise today? Consider the matter of blood fractions. Each Christian must make up his or her own mind about whether to accept or to reject these fractions.* We may find it a challenge to understand this matter fully, but making decisions like this is part of the load that each of us must carry. (Rom. 14:4) If we were to copy what somebody else decided to do, we could weaken our own conscience. We can train and improve our conscience only by using it. (Heb. 5:14) So when should we ask a mature Christian for advice? After we have done our

* For a detailed discussion of this topic, see the *Enjoy Life Forever!* book, lesson 39 point 5 and the “Explore” section.

17. What could happen if we just copy what others do? Give an example. (See also pictures.)

own research but still need help in understanding how Bible principles relate to our situation.

KEEP ON SEEKING ADVICE

¹⁸ Jehovah has shown great trust in us by allowing us to make our own decisions. He provides us with his Word, the Bible. And he gives us wise friends, who can help us to reason on Bible principles. He has fulfilled his responsibility as our Father. (Prov. 3:21-23) What can we do to show him our gratitude?

¹⁹ Consider this fact: Parents love to see their children mature and develop into thoughtful, wise, and helpful servants of Jehovah. Similarly, Jehovah is happy when he sees us continue to mature spiritually, to seek advice, and to make decisions that honor him.

18. What has Jehovah done for us?

19. How can we continue to make Jehovah happy?

PICTURE DESCRIPTIONS **Cover:** King David humbly accepted and applied Abigail’s advice. **Page 3:** An elder counsels a fellow elder regarding the way he spoke at a recent meeting.

TO BENEFIT FROM GOOD ADVICE, WHY MUST I . . .

- | | | |
|-------------------------|--------------------------------|--------------------------|
| ■ be humble and modest? | ■ keep an open mind and heart? | ■ make my own decisions? |
|-------------------------|--------------------------------|--------------------------|

SONG 87

Come! Be Refreshed

FOCUS

How to give effective advice.

How to Give Advice

“I will give you advice with my eye upon you.”—PS. 32:8.

HOW do you feel about giving advice? Some are happy to provide it. Others are reluctant to offer counsel, or advice, and feel awkward when delivering it. Either way, all of us are obliged to provide advice from time to time. Why? Because Jesus said that his true followers are identified by the love that they show for one another. (John 13:35) And one way that we prove our love is by giving our brothers and sisters counsel when it is needed. God’s Word says that “sweet friendship” springs from, or grows because of, “sincere counsel.”—Prov. 27:9.

² Elders especially need to be able to give advice effectively. Jehovah, through Jesus, has assigned these men to shepherd the congregation. (1 Pet. 5:2, 3) One of the ways they do that is by providing Bible-based counsel in their talks to the congregation. They must also give counsel to individual sheep, including those who have strayed from the flock. How can elders and, by extension, all of us give good advice?

³ We can learn much about being a good counselor by studying the example set by Bible characters, especially Jesus. One of the titles that he has been given is “Wonderful Counselor.” (**Read Isaiah 9:6.**) In this article, we

1. Who needs to give advice? Explain.
2. What must elders be able to do, and why? (See also the box “Counsel at the Midweek Meeting.”)
3. (a) How can we learn to be a good counselor? (Isaiah 9:6; see also the box “Imitate Jesus When Giving Advice.”) (b) What will we discuss in this article?

will discuss what we can do when we are **asked** to give advice and what we can do when we have to give counsel **without being asked**. We will also consider the importance of giving advice at the right time and in the right way.

WHEN WE ARE ASKED TO GIVE ADVICE

⁴ When someone asks us for advice, what should be our first reaction? We may be flattered and want to help immediately. But we should first ask ourselves, ‘Am I qualified to give advice in this area?’ Sometimes, the best way we can help is by not giving advice but instead directing the person to someone who is qualified to provide guidance on that subject.

4-5. When someone asks us for advice, what question should we first ask ourselves? Give an example.

⁵ Consider this example. Suppose that a close friend develops a serious medical condition. He tells you that he has started researching the treatment options that are available to him, and then he asks you to give your opinion on which treatment you feel is better. You may have strong personal opinions on the matter, but you have no medical qualifications or training in dealing with the illness. In that case, the best way you can help your friend is to assist him in finding someone who is qualified to help him.

⁶ Even if we feel that we are qualified to give advice on a particular topic, we may choose to wait for a short period of time before answering a person who asks us for advice. Why? Proverbs 15:28 says that “the righteous one meditates

6. Why may we choose to wait before we give advice?

Counsel at the Midweek Meeting

The chairman of the midweek meeting offers helpful suggestions to those who give student assignments. As the student presents his assignment, the chairman looks for how well the student applies the study point. After the assignment, the chairman offers sincere commendation. If needed, he also offers specific and tactful counsel on how the student can improve in applying the study point. Such counsel benefits not only the student but also the entire congregation.—Prov. 27:17.



before answering.” What if we think that we know the answer? We might still take some time to do research, to pray, and to meditate. Then we can be more confident that our answer is in harmony with Jehovah’s feelings on the matter. Note the example of the prophet Nathan.

⁷ When speaking with the prophet Nathan, King David said that he wanted to build a temple to Jehovah. Nathan im-

7. What do you learn from the prophet Nathan’s example?

mediately advised him to do it. But Nathan should have first taken time to consult Jehovah. Why? Because Jehovah did not want David to build the temple. (1 Chron. 17:1-4) As this incident shows, when we are asked to give advice, we are wise to be “slow to speak.”—Jas. 1:19.

⁸ Consider another reason why we should be careful when giving advice to someone: We could share responsibility

8. What is another reason why we should be careful when giving advice?

Imitate Jesus When Giving Advice

Note some of the things that make Jesus a “Wonderful Counselor,” and consider how we can follow his example.

- **Jesus knew what to say.** He always knew the right thing to say because he based his advice on Jehovah’s wisdom, never his own. He told his disciples: “The things I say to you I do not speak of my own originality.” —John 14:10.

The lesson: Although we may have accumulated a lot of experience and wisdom in life, we must make sure that the counsel we give is based, not on our own thoughts, but on God’s Word.

- **Jesus knew when to give advice.** He did not tell his disciples everything they needed to know all at once. Rather, he waited until it was the right time to counsel his disciples, and he told them only as much as they could bear.—John 16:12.

The lesson: When counseling someone, we need to wait until it is the right “time to speak.” (Eccl. 3:7) If we overwhelm the person with information, he may become confused and discouraged. So we do well to tell him only as much as he needs to know to deal with the challenge he is facing.

- **Jesus knew how to be tactful.** Jesus repeatedly had to give his apostles counsel about being humble. On each occasion, though, he was mild and respectful.—Matt. 18:1-5.

The lesson: Even if we must give someone the same counsel repeatedly, we will be most effective if we remain mild and speak respectfully.



Prepare the ground



Plant



Water

Giving unsolicited counsel takes love and skill
(See paragraphs 10-12)

if our counsel causes someone to make a decision that brings on negative consequences. Certainly, we have good reason to think carefully before giving advice.

GIVING COUNSEL WITHOUT BEING ASKED

⁹ From time to time, elders must take the initiative to give counsel to a brother or a sister who has taken “a false step.” **(Read Galatians 6:1.)** A study note on this verse says that such a person “is heading in the wrong direction, though he may not yet have committed a serious sin.” The goal of the elders is to help the person remain on the road that leads to everlasting life. (Jas. 5:19, 20) For their counsel to be effective, however, they first need to make sure that

9. Before giving counsel, of what must elders be sure? (Galatians 6:1)

the person has really taken a false step. Jehovah allows all of us to make decisions based on our own conscience. (Rom. 14:1-4) What, though, if a brother has indeed taken a false step and the elders decide that they must take the initiative to give him some counsel?

¹⁰ Elders who must give unsolicited counsel face a particular challenge. In what way? The apostle Paul said that a person might take a false step before he is aware of it. So the elders should first of all prepare the person to receive the counsel.

¹¹ Giving unsolicited counsel can be like trying to grow plants in hardened soil. Before a farmer starts sowing, he tills the soil. This softens the ground and prepares it to receive the seed. He then

10-12. When giving unsolicited counsel, what should elders do? Illustrate. (See also pictures.)

Even though his anger had flared up earlier, Elihu gave his counsel in a mild and deeply respectful manner (See paragraph 15)



plants the seed. Finally, he waters the seed to help it grow. Similarly, before an elder gives unsolicited counsel, he does well to prepare the ground, so to speak. For example, at a convenient time to talk, the elder assures the brother that he has his best interests at heart. If a counselor has the reputation of being loving and kind, it will be easier for others to accept his advice.

¹² During the discussion, the elder can continue to soften the ground by acknowledging that everyone makes mistakes and needs counsel from time to time. (Rom. 3:23) In a calm voice and with deep respect, the elder clearly shows him from the Scriptures how he has taken a false step. Once the brother acknowledges that he has made a mistake, the elder “plants the seed” by explaining to him, in simple terms, what he needs to do to try to correct the situation. Finally, the elder “waters” the seed by sincerely commending the brother and by praying with him.—Jas. 5:15.

¹³ Sometimes, what the counselor *says*

13. How can elders make sure that the person understands the counsel?

and what the person receiving the counsel *hears* are two different things. What can elders do to keep that from happening? They can drive the key points home by respectfully asking tactful questions. (Eccl. 12:11) The answers will help the counselor make sure that the person understands the counsel he was given.

GIVING ADVICE AT THE RIGHT TIME AND IN THE RIGHT WAY

¹⁴ We are all imperfect, so we are bound to do or to say things that upset others. (Col. 3:13) God’s Word acknowledges that we may at times even cause one another to become wrathful. (Eph. 4:26) But we must resist the urge to give advice when we are angry. Why? Because “man’s anger does not bring about God’s righteousness.” (Jas. 1:20) If we give advice when we are angry, we are likely to do more harm than good. This does not mean that we should never express our thoughts and feelings to the one who angered us. However, we can communicate more effectively if we wait until we are calm. Note the good ex-

14. Should we give advice when we are angry? Explain.

ample set by Job's faithful counselor, Elihu.

¹⁵ Elihu spent days listening to Job defend himself from the accusations of his false comforters. Elihu felt compassion for Job. But Elihu also became hot with anger because Job had misrepresented Jehovah and had focused too much on himself. Even so, Elihu waited for his turn and then spoke in a mild and deeply respectful manner when counseling Job. (Job 32:2; 33:1-7) Elihu's example teaches us an important truth: Advice is best given at the right time and in the right way—with respect and love.—Eccl. 3:1, 7.

CONTINUE TO GIVE AND TO ACCEPT ADVICE

¹⁶ The theme text for this article says that 'Jehovah gives advice with his eye

15. What do we learn from Elihu's example? (See also picture.)

16. What lesson do you learn from Psalm 32:8?

upon us.' **(Read Psalm 32:8.)** This indicates that he provides ongoing support for us. He not only gives advice but also helps us to apply it. What a good example that is for us! When we have the privilege of giving advice to others, may we imitate Jehovah by keeping our eye upon them and providing whatever support we can to help them succeed.

¹⁷ Now more than ever, we need to give and to receive good advice. (2 Tim. 3:1) Elders who give specific, Bible-based advice are "like streams of water in a waterless land." **(Read Isaiah 32:1, 2.)** Friends who know what we *want* to hear but tell us what we *need* to hear give us a gift as valuable as "apples of gold in silver carvings." (Prov. 25:11) May all of us continue to develop the wisdom we need to give and to receive good advice.

17. When elders give specific, Bible-based advice, what do they prove to be? Explain. (Isaiah 32:1, 2)

WHAT MUST WE REMEMBER WHEN WE . . .

■ are asked to give advice?

■ must give unsolicited counsel?

■ are angry?

SONG 97

Life Depends
on God's Word

FOCUS

How to apply valuable lessons from basic Bible teachings, even years after you first learned them.

Can You Still Learn From Basic Bible Teachings?

"I intend always to remind you of these things, although you know them and are well-established in the truth."—2 PET. 1:12.

BASIC Bible teachings have changed our life. For example, when we learned that God's name is Jehovah, we took the first step in becoming his friend. (Isa. 42:8) When we learned the true condition of the dead, we no longer wondered whether our dead loved ones were suffering. (Eccl. 9:10) And when we learned about God's promise of Paradise on earth, we no longer worried about our future. We were confident that our life could last, not just for a short time—70 or 80 years—but forever.—Ps. 37:29; 90:10.

² We must never take for granted the basic teachings of the Bible. In his second letter, the apostle Peter wrote to Christians who were "well-established in the truth." (**Read 2 Peter 1:12, 13.**) Now, however, they faced spiritual dangers within the congregation, including false teachers and ungodly men. (2 Pet. 2:1-3) Peter wanted to strengthen his brothers and sisters in order to help them resist these threats. To do so, he reminded them of

1. How did Bible teachings affect you when you first learned the truth?
2. How does 2 Peter 1:12, 13 indicate that even mature Christians benefit from basic Scriptural teachings?

some of the teachings they had already learned. These teachings would help them to keep their integrity until the end.

³ As we grow in Christian maturity, we may be able to draw new lessons from basic Bible teachings. To illustrate: A skilled chef and one who is a novice may use the same basic ingredients when preparing a dish. But over time, the experienced chef has learned to get the most out of those ingredients and to prepare them in new and interesting ways. Similarly, longtime servants of Jehovah and new Bible students may look at basic Bible truths from different angles. Our circumstances or privileges of service have likely changed since we got baptized. When we apply the teachings that we learned long ago to our current situation, we may discover new and practical lessons. Let us see what

3. Illustrate why all Christians should continue to meditate on basic Bible teachings.

mature Christians can learn from three basic Bible teachings.

JEHOVAH IS THE CREATOR

⁴ “The one who constructed all things is God.” (Heb. 3:4) We know that our planet and the life on it were made by an all-wise and all-powerful Creator. He made us, so he knows us through and through. What is more, he cares about us. He knows what is best for us. Knowing this simple truth, that Jehovah is the Creator, has affected us in a profound way, giving our life real meaning and purpose.

⁵ The truth that Jehovah is the Creator can teach us a lesson in **humility**. After Job became too focused on himself and on other humans, Jehovah reminded

4. How has learning that Jehovah is the Creator affected us?

5. What truth can help us to cultivate humility? (Isaiah 45:9-12)

What can help us to maintain a proper view of our own ideas?

(See paragraph 6)



him that He is the almighty Creator. (Job 38:1-4) This reminder helped Job to see that God's ways are superior to man's ways. In line with this, the prophet Isaiah later wrote: "Should the clay say to the Potter: 'What are you making?'"—**Read Isaiah 45:9-12.**

⁶ As a Christian gains experience, he could begin to put too much trust in his own opinions rather than look to Jehovah and His Word for guidance. (Job 37: 23, 24) But what if a person thinks deeply about the incomparable wisdom and greatness of his Creator? (Isa. 40:22; 55: 8, 9) This fundamental truth will help him to remain humble and to put his own ideas in perspective.

⁷ Rahela, who lives in Slovenia, has found that thinking about her Creator has helped her to accept a change in organizational direction. She admits: "Sometimes, it hasn't been easy for me to accept decisions made by those who take the lead. For example, even after I watched the *2023 Governing Body Update #8*, I was shocked the first time I saw a bearded brother giving a talk. So I prayed to Jehovah to help me adapt to this change." Rahela recognized that as the Creator of heaven and earth, Jehovah is perfectly capable of guiding his organization in the right direction. If you find it hard to adjust to a new understanding or to accept new direction, why not humbly meditate on the superior wisdom and power of our Creator?—Rom. 11:33-36.

6. When might we reflect on Jehovah's exalted position as our Creator? (See also pictures.)

7. What did Rahela do to accept a change in direction?

WHY GOD PERMITS SUFFERING

⁸ Why does God permit suffering? Some who have been unable to answer that question have become angry at God or have concluded that he does not exist at all! (Prov. 19:3) By contrast, you have learned that inherited sin and imperfection, not Jehovah, have caused suffering. You have also learned that Jehovah's patience with humans has allowed millions to come to know him and to see for themselves how Jehovah will end suffering permanently. (2 Pet. 3:9, 15) These truths have reassured you and drawn you closer to him.

⁹ We understand the need to be *patient* while we wait for Jehovah to end suffering. Yet, when we or our loved ones experience distress, injustice, or loss, we may wonder why Jehovah is not acting more quickly. (Hab. 1:2, 3) At such times, we are wise to reflect on the reasons why Jehovah allows the righteous to suffer hardship.* (Ps. 34:19) We can also reflect on his purpose to bring suffering to an end once and for all.

¹⁰ The truth about suffering can help us to endure. Anne, who lives on the island of Mayotte, in the Indian Ocean, relates: "The loss of my mother a few years ago made me very sad. However, I regularly remind myself that Jehovah is not responsible for suffering. He is eager

* See the article "Why All Suffering Is Soon to End" in the May 15, 2007, issue of *The Watchtower*, pp. 21-25.

8. How has learning why God permits suffering benefited us?

9. In what situations might we recall the reasons why Jehovah permits suffering?

10. How has Anne coped with the loss of her mother?

to get rid of all forms of suffering and resurrect our loved ones. Meditating on those truths provides me with a peace of mind that often surprises me.”

¹¹ Knowing the truth about why God permits suffering can motivate us to keep preaching. After explaining that Jehovah’s patience means salvation for those who repent, Peter wrote: “Consider what sort of people you ought to be in holy acts of conduct and deeds of godly devotion.” (2 Pet. 3:11) Among those “deeds of godly devotion” is our field ministry. Like our Father, we love people. We want them to live in God’s righteous new world. Jehovah is patiently giving the people in your community an opportunity to worship him. What a privilege you have to be God’s fellow worker and to help as many as possible to learn about him before the end comes!—1 Cor. 3:9.

WE ARE LIVING IN “THE LAST DAYS”

¹² The Bible accurately describes what people would be like during “the last days.” (2 Tim. 3:1-5) We have only to look around us to see how this prophecy is being fulfilled. As we see the attitudes of people worsen, we become more convinced than ever that God’s Word is trustworthy.—2 Tim. 3:13-15.

¹³ We respond to the truth that we are living in the last days with a **sense of urgency**. Note what we can learn about

11. How can Jehovah’s reasons for permitting suffering help us to continue preaching?

12. How has learning that we are living in “the last days” benefited us?

13. In harmony with Jesus’ illustration found at Luke 12:15-21, what might we ask ourselves?

urgency from Jesus’ illustration found at **Luke 12:15-21**. (**Read.**) Why was the rich man called “unreasonable”? Not because the man was wealthy, but because he had the wrong priorities. He stored up “treasure for himself but [was] not rich toward God.” What made the matter so urgent? God told the man: “This night they are demanding your life from you.” Today, as this system of things draws to a close, we might ask ourselves: ‘What do my goals reveal about my sense of urgency? What about the goals I help my children to set? Do I use my strength, my time, and my financial resources primarily to build up treasures for myself or to store up treasures in heaven?’

¹⁴ Our entire outlook on life can change when we think about the evidence that we are living in the last days. That is what happened to a sister named Miki. She relates: “When I graduated from school, my heart was leading me toward a career in the study of animals. I also had the goal of regular pioneering and of serving where the need is greater. Mature friends advised me to think very carefully about whether it was realistic for me to pursue the secular career I wanted and still reach my spiritual goals. They reminded me that this system will soon come to an end. On the other hand, in the new world, I will have an eternity to study as many animals as I like. So I chose a short, practical program. This allowed me to get employment to support me in regular

14. As illustrated by Miki’s experience, why is it wise to meditate on the Scriptural evidence that we are living in the last days?



**What can motivate us not to give up
on our unbelieving relatives?**
(See paragraph 15)

pioneering and later to move to Ecuador, where the need is greater.” Miki and her husband now serve in the circuit work in that country.

¹⁵ We should not be discouraged when people initially reject the good news. People can change. Consider the example of Jesus’ half brother James. He watched Jesus grow up, become the Messiah, and teach as no other human had taught. Yet, for years, James did not follow Jesus. Only after Jesus was resurrected did his brother become a disciple—and a zealous one at that!* (John 7:5; Gal. 2:9) Do not underestimate the value of reaching out to relatives who have not yet shown interest or of calling again on those who have not accepted the Kingdom message. Remember that we are living in the last days, so our preaching work is urgent. What you say to them today may affect them later,

* See lesson 8 of the brochure *Love People—Make Disciples*.

15. How might people still respond to the good news? Give an example. (See also pictures.)

perhaps even after the great tribulation starts.*

REMAIN GRATEFUL FOR JEHOVAH’S REMINDERS

¹⁶ Some of the spiritual food that we receive is prepared for people who have never heard basic Bible truths. For example, our weekly public talk, certain articles and videos on jw.org, and our public magazines are designed primarily for non-Witnesses. Even so, we benefit from those reminders. They deepen our love for Jehovah, strengthen our faith in his Word, and help us to be more effective when teaching basic truths to others.—Ps. 19:7.

¹⁷ As Jehovah’s Witnesses, we are thrilled when our understanding of a

* See the article “What Do We Know About Jehovah’s Future Judgments?” in the May 2024 issue of *The Watchtower*, pp. 8-13.

16. How have you benefited from Jehovah’s reminders? (See also the box “Use Them to Help Others.”)

17. In what situations might you reflect on basic Bible teachings?

Scriptural truth is clarified. Yet, we are also deeply grateful for the fundamental Bible teachings that drew us to the truth in the first place. If we are ever tempted to insist on our own opinion rather than to submit to guidance from Jehovah's organization, we can humbly remember who is directing that organization—the almighty and all-wise Creator. When we or a loved one is enduring a trial, we can be patient and reflect on why Jehovah has allowed suffering. And when deciding where to focus our time and resources, we can recall the urgency of these last days. May Jehovah's reminders continue to strengthen us, motivate us, and make us wise.

PICTURE DESCRIPTIONS: **Page 15:** An elder's suggestion is not adopted by the body of elders. Later, under a starry sky, he is moved to see his own ideas in the proper perspective. **Page 18:** During her personal study, a Witness examines evidence that we are living in the last days. This moves her to call her sister and witness to her.

Use Them to Help Others

When you read an article, watch a video, or listen to a talk that has been prepared for newly interested people, consider how you can use the material to help others. You might ask yourself:

- 'What evidence is being used to convince the audience?'
- 'Is there an effective illustration that I could use when I teach this truth to someone?'
- 'Who might be interested in this topic, and when could I share this truth with him?'

WHAT PRACTICAL LESSONS CAN BE DRAWN FROM THESE BASIC BIBLE TEACHINGS?

- | | | |
|--------------------------|-----------------------------|------------------------------------|
| ■ Jehovah is the Creator | ■ Why God permits suffering | ■ We are living in "the last days" |
|--------------------------|-----------------------------|------------------------------------|

SONG 111

Our Reasons for Joy

FOCUS

Learning to be content by cultivating gratitude, by being focused and humble, and by meditating on our hope for the future.

Have You “Learned the Secret” of Contentment?

“I have learned to be self-sufficient regardless of my circumstances.”—PHIL. 4:11.

ARE you a contented person? Someone who is content finds joy and peace by focusing on his current blessings. He does not feel bitter or angry because of what he lacks. Nevertheless, being content does not mean being complacent. For example, a Christian rightly reaches out for opportunities to expand his service. (Rom. 12:1; 1 Tim. 3:1) Even so, he does not lose his joy if privileges of service do not come as quickly as he had expected.

² Discontentment can lead to serious consequences. Those who are never satisfied with what they have may work extremely long hours to obtain material things that are not really needed. Sadly, a few Christians have even stolen money and other things they desired. They may have told themselves, ‘I deserve it,’ ‘I have waited long enough,’ or ‘I will pay the money back later.’ Yet, stealing of any kind displeases and dishonors Jehovah. (Prov. 30:9) Others have become so disappointed at not receiving a privilege of service that they have given up serving Jehovah altogether. (Gal. 6:9) How could a dedicated worshipper of Jehovah even think of doing that? The problem may be that the person has stopped cultivating contentment.

1. What does contentment mean, and what does it not mean?
2. Why is discontentment so dangerous?

³ We all can cultivate contentment. The apostle Paul wrote that he had “learned to be self-sufficient regardless of [his] circumstances.” (**Read Philip-
pians 4:11, 12.**) He wrote those words while imprisoned. Even so, he had not lost his joy. He had “learned the secret” of contentment. If we struggle to be content, Paul’s words and experience can assure us that we can develop contentment. We should not expect that we will naturally feel content with our circumstances. Rather, we must *learn* to be content. How? Let us discuss qualities that will help us learn the secret of contentment.

3. What assuring truth do we learn about at Philip-
pians 4:11, 12?

CULTIVATE GRATITUDE

⁴ A grateful spirit nurtures contentment. (**Read 1 Thessalonians 5:18.**) For example, when we are truly thankful for the necessities of life, we are less likely to be overly concerned about the things we want but do not have. When we reflect appreciatively on the privileges of service we enjoy now, we will focus on doing our best in those assignments instead of becoming obsessed with receiving a new privilege. No wonder the Scriptures urge us to include expressions of thanks to Jehovah in our prayers! Having a grateful spirit helps us to feel “the peace of God that

4. How does having a grateful spirit help us to be content? (1 Thessalonians 5:18)

Why did the Israelites become discontent?

(See paragraph 5)



surpasses all understanding.”—Phil. 4: 6, 7.

⁵ Consider what happened to the Israelites. On a number of occasions, they complained to Jehovah that they lacked the food they used to enjoy in Egypt. (Num. 11:4-6) Granted, life in the wilderness was not easy. What would have helped them to be content? They should have reflected gratefully on what Jehovah had already done for them. In Egypt, where they were brutally treated as slaves, Jehovah brought ten plagues on their captors. After the Israelites were set free, they “plundered the Egyptians” of silver, gold, and clothing. (Ex. 12:35, 36) When the Israelites were chased to the edge of the Red Sea, Jehovah miraculously parted the waters. And as they traveled through the wilderness, he fed them daily with manna. What, then, was the problem? The Israelites were discontent, not because they lacked the food they needed, but because they were not grateful for what they already had.

⁶ How, then, can you cultivate gratitude? First, make time each day to think about the good things you enjoy. You might even write down two or three things you are grateful for. (Lam. 3:22, 23) Second, express your gratitude. Take the initiative to thank others for what they do for you. Above all, thank Jehovah regularly. (Ps. 75:1) Third, choose as close friends those who are thankful. Gratitude is contagious; so is dis-

contentment. (Deut. 1:26-28; 2 Tim. 3:1, 2, 5) When we are focused on expressing gratitude, we are less likely to be consumed by feelings of discontent.

⁷ Consider what happened to Aci, who lives in Indonesia. She admits: “During the COVID-19 pandemic, I began to compare my circumstances with those of my fellow believers. As a result, I became discontent.” (Gal. 6:4) What helped her to change her thinking? Aci says: “I started to count the blessings I was receiving each day and to reflect on the many good things I had gained from being part of God’s organization. Then I expressed my gratitude to Jehovah. As a result, I came to feel truly content.” If you have negative thoughts overwhelming you, could you take similar steps to regain a grateful spirit?

STAY FOCUSED AND REMAIN HUMBLE

⁸ The prophet Jeremiah’s secretary, Baruch, temporarily fell into a trap. Baruch had a difficult assignment, namely, to support Jeremiah as he delivered a strong message to an ungrateful nation. At one point, Baruch lost his focus. Instead of concentrating on what Jehovah wanted him to do, he apparently began thinking too much about himself and what he wanted to do. Through Jeremiah, Jehovah told Baruch: “You are seeking great things for yourself. Stop seeking such things.” (Jer. 45:3-5) In other words, he was saying: “Be content with your present circumstances.” Bar-

5. For what reasons should the Israelites have been grateful? (See also picture.)

6. What are some ways that we can cultivate gratitude?

7. How did Aci cultivate gratitude, and with what result?

8. What trap did Baruch fall into?



Any gift we have is an expression
of Jehovah's undeserved kindness
(See paragraph 9)

uch accepted the correction and continued to enjoy Jehovah's approval.

⁹ At times, a Christian may feel that he is entitled to a certain privilege of service. He might be very talented, hard-working, or experienced—or perhaps all three. However, others may receive the very privilege he would like to have. How could he reason on the matter? He could reflect on what the apostle Paul wrote, as found at **1 Corinthians 4:6, 7. (Read.)** Every privilege we receive and every talent we have comes from Jehovah. We do not earn or deserve these gifts. They are all expressions of Jehovah's **undeserved** kindness.—Rom. 12:3, 6; Eph. 2:8, 9.

¹⁰ We can cultivate humility by thinking deeply about the example that Je-

sus set for us. Consider what happened on the night that Jesus washed his apostles' feet. The apostle John wrote: "Jesus, knowing [1] that the Father had given all things into his hands and [2] that he came from God and [3] was going to God, . . . started to wash the feet of the disciples." (John 13:3-5) Jesus could have felt entitled to have his own feet washed. But during his life on earth, he never felt that he deserved a more prosperous and comfortable life. (Luke 9:58) Jesus was humble; he was content. He set a perfect pattern for us.—John 13:15.

¹¹ Dennis, from the Netherlands, has tried to follow Jesus' pattern of humility, but it has not been easy. He says: "Sometimes I notice feelings of pride or discontent growing in me, such as when someone else receives a privilege of

9. According to 1 Corinthians 4:6, 7, what will humility move us to recognize? (See also pictures.)

10. How can we cultivate humility?

11. How has humility helped Dennis to feel content?

service. When that happens, I study the topic of humility. In the *JW Library*® app, I have tagged certain scriptures about humility so that I can find them quickly and reread them. I have also downloaded to my phone some talks about humility, and I listen to them often.* I have learned that all the work we do is so that we can glorify Jehovah, not ourselves. Each of us plays a small role in what Jehovah is accomplishing.” If you begin to feel dissatisfied with your situation, take steps to cultivate humility. This will strengthen your friendship with Jehovah and help you to feel content.—Jas. 4:6, 8.

MEDITATE ON YOUR HOPE

¹² We feel more content when we meditate on the wonderful hope ahead of us. Jehovah’s own words recorded by the prophet Isaiah acknowledge how frustrating life can be today and assure us that Jehovah will relieve those frustrations. **(Read Isaiah 65:21-25.)** We will live in safe and comfortable housing. We will have meaningful work, and we will eat healthful and delicious food. We will never again worry about dangers to ourselves or to our children. (Isa. 32:17, 18; Ezek. 34:25) Our future is wonderful, and it is secure.

¹³ Now more than ever, we need to focus on our hope. Why? Because we are living in “the last days” and we all have

* For example, watch on jw.org the Morning Worship programs *Jehovah Cares for the Humble* and *Pride Is Before a Crash*.

12. What hope for the future helps us to be content? (Isaiah 65:21-25)

13. In what circumstances might we especially need to focus on our hope?

problems that are “hard to deal with.” (2 Tim. 3:1) Jehovah daily helps us to endure by giving us the guidance, strength, and support we need. (Ps. 145:14) In addition, our Christian hope can sustain us during difficult times. Perhaps you struggle to provide for your family’s material needs. Does this mean that you will always have to struggle to survive? Absolutely not! Jehovah has promised to give you what you need—and much, much more—in Paradise. (Ps. 9:18; 72:12-14) You may be dealing with chronic pain, depression, or some other debilitating health condition. Is this simply your lot in life, with no hope of relief—ever? Not at all. Sickness and death will vanish in God’s new world. (Rev. 21:3, 4) That hope helps us to feel content—free of anger and bitterness—right now. We can feel content while facing injustice or loss, enduring sickness, or any other trial. Why? Because no matter how difficult our present challenges may be, we know that our “tribulation is momentary” and that the new world will soon provide permanent relief.—2 Cor. 4:17, 18.

¹⁴ Since hope is vital to our contentment, how can we strengthen it? Just as a person may need to put on eyeglasses to see distant objects more clearly, we might need to take appropriate steps to strengthen our hope so that we can see the future Paradise more clearly. When we are consumed by worry about our finances, we can picture what our life will be like when money, debt, and economic inequality are gone. If we are anxious about privileges of service that we have

14. How can we strengthen our hope?

not yet received, we can think about how insignificant such anxieties will be after we reach perfection and have served Jehovah for thousands of years. (1 Tim. 6:19) We may at first find it challenging to meditate on the future instead of worrying about the present. Over time, however, looking to the future that Jehovah has promised can become natural to us.

¹⁵ Consider how hope has helped Christa, who is married to Dennis, quoted earlier. She relates: “I have a progressive muscle disease that forces me to use a wheelchair and to spend most of the day in bed. I am in pain every day. My doctor recently told me that my prospects do not look good. But I immediately thought, ‘He sees the future differently.’ I’m focused on my hope, which gives me peace of mind. Today, I may have to endure living in this world, but I will fully enjoy the new world!”

“THOSE WHO FEAR HIM LACK NOTHING”

¹⁶ A contented servant of Jehovah will still face problems. King David suffered

15. What do you learn from Christa’s comments?

16. Why could King David write that those who fear Jehovah “lack nothing”?

the loss of at least three of his children. He was wrongly accused, betrayed, and hunted as a fugitive for years. Still, while enduring a severe trial, he said of Jehovah: “Those who fear him lack nothing.” (Ps. 34:9, 10) Why could he say that? Because although we, as Jehovah’s people, do not expect a trouble free life, we are certain that we will never lack what we truly need. (Ps. 145:16) And we can count on Jehovah to sustain us through all our trials. We can be content.

¹⁷ Jehovah wants you to be content. (Ps. 131:1, 2) So endeavor to learn the secret of contentment. If you work hard to cultivate gratitude, to remain focused and humble, and to strengthen your hope, you will be able to say: “Yes, I am content.”—Ps. 16:5, 6.

17. Why are you determined to learn the secret of contentment?

PICTURE DESCRIPTION Page 23: A brother performs maintenance work at a theocratic facility, a sister who has learned sign language is interviewed at a circuit assembly, and a brother delivers a public talk.

HOW DO THE FOLLOWING HELP YOU TO BE CONTENT?

■ Cultivating gratitude

■ Remaining focused and humble

■ Meditating on your hope

“The Battle Belongs to Jehovah”

AS TOLD BY PHILIP BRUMLEY



JANUARY 28, 2010, found me on a cold winter's day in picturesque Strasbourg, France. But the last thing on my mind was touring. I was there as part of a legal team assigned to defend the rights of Jehovah's Witnesses before the European Court of Human Rights (ECHR). At issue was whether the government of France was justified in demanding that our brothers there pay an astronomical tax of almost 64 million euros (\$89,000,000 U.S.). More important, Jehovah's name, the reputation of his people, and their ability to worship him freely were at stake. What took place at that hearing confirmed that “the battle belongs to Jehovah.” (1 Sam. 17:47) Let me explain.

The controversy had begun in the late 1990's when the government of France levied an unjustified tax on the donations that our France branch had received between 1993 and 1996. We sought justice before the courts in France, but to no avail. After we lost in an appellate court, the government confiscated money from the branch's bank account worth over four and a half million euros (\$6,300,000 U.S.). Our final hope rested with the ECHR. But before ruling on the dispute, the ECHR required that we and the government's legal team attend a pretrial settlement hearing before one of the Court's registrars, officials responsible for the administrative and judicial activities of the Court.

We anticipated that the registrar would pressure us to resolve the matter by agreeing to pay a portion of the amount demanded. However, we clearly understood that paying even one euro would violate Bible principles. The brothers and sisters had donated to support Kingdom interests, so their donations did not belong to the government. (Matt. 22:21) Still, we attended out of respect for the Court's protocols.

We met for the hearing in one of the Court's elegant conference rooms. The

hearing did not begin well. In her opening comments, the registrar confirmed that she expected Jehovah's Witnesses in France to pay some of the levied tax. We suddenly felt impelled to ask her, "Are you aware that the government has **already** confiscated over four and a half million euros from our bank account?"

She was visibly shocked. When the government's legal team confirmed that they had done so, her attitude toward the case changed completely. She scolded them and abruptly concluded the hearing. I realized then that Jehovah had, in a way we could never have anticipated, completely altered the course of this litigation. We left the hearing elated, barely believing what had taken place.

On June 30, 2011, the ECHR issued a unanimous decision in our favor. It annulled the tax and ordered the government to refund the money it had seized, plus interest! This historic ruling has protected pure worship in France to this day. That single, unrehearsed question we asked, like the stone

that sunk into Goliath's head, was the turning point of the battle. Why did we win? Because, as David told Goliath, "the battle belongs to Jehovah."—1 Sam. 17:45-47.

This victory is not the exception. To date, in the face of powerful political and religious opposition, the highest courts of 70 countries and several international tribunals have handed down 1,225 decisions in favor of Jehovah's Witnesses. These legal victories protect our fundamental rights, such as our right to have legal status as a religion, to engage in the public ministry, to refuse to participate in patriotic ceremonies, and to refuse blood.

How did I come to be involved in a legal case in Europe while serving at the World Headquarters of Jehovah's Witnesses in New York, U.S.A.?

MOLDED BY MISSIONARY ZEAL

My parents, George and Lucille, graduated from the 12th class of Gilead and were serving in Ethiopia when I was born in 1956. They named me Philip, after the



Our legal team in front of the ECHR, 2010

first-century evangelizer. (Acts 21:8) The following year, the government banned our worship. Although I was just a toddler, I clearly remember my family worshipping in secret. As a child, I thought it was exciting! Sadly, officials forced us to leave the country in 1960.

When our family relocated to Wichita, Kansas, U.S.A., my parents brought something very special with them—their inspiring missionary zeal. They lived the truth and instilled spiritual values not only in me but also in my older sister, Judy, and my younger brother, Leslie, both of whom had also been born in Ethiopia. I got baptized at the age of 13. Three years later, our family moved to serve where the need was greater, in Arequipa, Peru.

In 1974 when I was just 18, the Peru branch assigned me and four other brothers to serve as special pioneers. We were to preach in untouched territories, high in the Central Andes Mountains. This included witnessing to the indigenous Quechua and Aymara communities. We traveled in a motor home affectionately called The Ark because



“The Ark,” 1974

of its boxlike appearance. I treasure memories of using the Bible to show the indigenous people that Jehovah will soon do away with poverty, sickness, and death. (Rev. 21: 3, 4) Many accepted the Kingdom message.

OFF TO WORLD HEADQUARTERS

During a 1977 visit to Peru, Albert Schroeder, who was a member of the Governing Body of Jehovah’s Witnesses, encouraged me to apply for Bethel service at world headquarters. So I did. Soon after, on June 17, 1977, I began my service at Brooklyn Bethel. Over the next four years, I worked in the Cleaning and Maintenance departments.

In June 1978, I met Elizabeth Avallone at an international convention in New Orleans, Louisiana. She had been raised by parents who, like mine, lived the truth. Elizabeth had been serving as a regular pioneer for four years, and she treasured full-time service as a way of life. We kept in touch. Before long, we fell very much in love. We got married on October 20, 1979, and we started Bethel service as a couple.

The brothers and sisters in our first congregation, Brooklyn Spanish, opened their hearts to us. Through the years, three other

Nathan H. Knorr (far left) visiting my family in Addis Ababa, Ethiopia, 1959



**A. On our wedding day,
1979**



**B. Bethelites associated
with the Brooklyn
Spanish Congregation,
1986**



loving congregations have welcomed us and supported our Bethel service. We treasure their backing, as well as the support of friends and family who helped us care for our parents in their old age.

JOINING OUR LEGAL WARFARE

To my surprise, I was assigned in January 1982 to serve in the Legal Department at Bethel. Three years later, I was asked to attend law school and to become a licensed attorney. I was pleasantly surprised to learn during my studies that the fundamental freedoms that most people take for granted, both in the United States and internationally, were strengthened by legal victories won by Jehovah's Witnesses. These key cases were discussed extensively in class.

In 1986 when I was 30, I was appointed as the overseer of the Legal Department. Since I was so young and barely grasped the complexity of what lay ahead, I felt both privileged and overwhelmed.

I qualified as an attorney in 1988, but I was dangerously unaware of what I had allowed this accomplishment to do to my spirituality. Higher education can nurture a desire for self-promotion and foster the notion that having specialized knowledge elevates a person above others who do not have a similar education. Elizabeth came to my res-

cue. She helped me reestablish the spiritual routine I had before law school. It took time, but I gradually recovered spiritually. I can attest that having a head full of specialized knowledge is not the most important thing in life. What brings true value to life is having a close relationship with Jehovah and a deep love for him and his people.

DEFENDING AND LEGALLY ESTABLISHING THE GOOD NEWS

With law school behind me, I focused on helping to organize the legal services needed at Bethel and defending Kingdom interests in court. Supporting our fast-moving, growing, and innovative organization was both exciting and challenging. In the early 1990's, for example, the Legal Department was asked to take the lead in changing our long-standing custom of asking for a suggested contribution for publications. Jehovah's Witnesses thereafter made these available without charge. This simplified the work at Bethel and in the field and to this day protects these activities from unwarranted taxation. Some thought that this change would deplete our resources and hinder our public ministry. The opposite happened. The number of those serving Jehovah since 1990 has more than doubled, and today people can have access to



lifesaving spiritual food without charge. I have personally witnessed that it is only through the strength Jehovah gives and the direction he provides by means of the faithful slave that this and so many other organizational adjustments can be successfully implemented.—Ex. 15:2; Matt. 24:45.

Legal victories are seldom solely the result of good advocacy in court. Often, what moves those in authority is the fine conduct of Jehovah's people. I saw an example of this in 1998 when three members of the Governing Body and their wives attended special conventions in Cuba. Their kind, respectful demeanor did more to convince the authorities of our political neutrality than anything we said to them in formal meetings.

However, when legal matters cannot be resolved amicably, we 'defend and legally establish the good news' in court. (Phil. 1:7) For example, for decades the authorities in Europe and South Korea did not recognize our right to refuse to perform military service. As a result, some 18,000 brothers in Europe and over 19,000 brothers in South Korea spent time in jail because of their conscientious objection to military service.

Finally, on July 7, 2011, the ECHR handed down the historic decision *Bayatyan v. Armenia* that mandates providing for alter-

native civilian service throughout Europe. That was followed by a similar decision by the South Korean Constitutional Court on June 28, 2018. Neither victory would have been obtained if even a small percentage of our young brothers had compromised.

Our oversight and legal departments at branches worldwide are working tirelessly in defense of Kingdom interests. We are honored to represent our brothers and sisters who are confronted by official opposition. Regardless of whether we prevail in court or not, our litigation results in a witness to governors and kings and to the nations. (Matt. 10:18) Judges, government representatives, the media, and the public in general must consider the scriptures that we include in our legal submissions and in our oral arguments. Honesthearted ones learn who Jehovah's Witnesses are and the source of their beliefs. Some of these individuals have become our fellow believers.

THANK YOU, JEHOVAH!

Over the past 40 years, I have been privileged to collaborate on legal matters with branch offices worldwide and to appear before numerous high courts and many high officials. I love and admire my fellow workers in the Legal Department at world headquarters and in the legal departments around the world. My life has been richly blessed and very fulfilling.

Elizabeth has loyally and lovingly supported me throughout the past 45 years, in good times and in bad times. I admire her for that because she has done so despite dealing with an illness that compromises her immune system and limits her strength.

We have personally witnessed that strength and victory do not come from our own abilities. As David said, "Jehovah is a strength for his people." (Ps. 28:8) Indeed, "the battle belongs to Jehovah."

DID YOU KNOW?



In the first century, how did the temple priests dispose of blood from sacrificial animals?

EVERY year, the priests in ancient Israel offered thousands of animal sacrifices on the altar of the temple. According to first-century Jewish historian Josephus, on Passover, more than 250,000 lambs were sacrificed, resulting in a large amount of blood being poured out. (Lev. 1:10, 11; Num. 28:16, 19) What happened to all that blood?

Archaeologists have uncovered an extensive drainage system in Herod's temple that was used until the temple's destruction in 70 C.E. The drainage system was evidently used to dispose of blood from the temple mount.

Consider two features of that drainage system:

- **Holes at the base of the altar:** A description of a drainage system for the altar is found in the Mishnah, a collection of Jewish oral laws compiled toward the early part of the third century C.E. It says: "At the south-western corner there were two holes . . . by which the blood that was poured over the western base and the southern base used to run down and mingle in the

water-channel and flow out into the brook Kidron."

This ancient tradition of "holes" near the altar harmonizes with the findings of modern archaeologists. *The Cambridge History of Judaism* confirms the discovery of "an extensive drainage system" near the temple. It states: "This was probably used to drain the water mixed with blood of the sacrifices which came out of the Temple Mount."

- **An adequate water supply:** The priests needed ample amounts of water to keep the altar's base and the drainage channel clean. To carry out this important task, the priests had access to a constant supply of fresh water from the city. That system was made up of canals, aqueducts, cisterns, and pools. Archaeologist Joseph Patrich remarked: "Such an elaborate system of water supply, cleansing and draining a temple precinct, is unique in antiquity."

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STUDY TIP

Study to Share

Study sessions can refresh us, but we can gain even more refreshment when we share with others the encouraging spiritual gems that we find. Proverbs 11:25 says: “Whoever refreshes others will himself be refreshed.”

When we share what we learn with others, we can thereafter remember the points more easily and deepen our understanding. And because those points can benefit others, it makes us happy to share such gems with them.—Acts 20:35.

Try this: In the coming week, look for an opportunity to share what you have learned with someone else. You might do so with a family member, someone in your congregation, a workmate, a schoolmate, a neighbor, or someone you meet in the field ministry. Try to express the information in your own words simply and clearly.

Remember: Share what you learn to encourage others, not to impress them.—1 Cor. 8:1.

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